

inherent in any transaction involving real property. And that, in itself, is sufficient to give him a head start on the road to successful real estate investment.

227

FINE ART: THE FINEST

INVESTMENT

Newspaper editors seldom allot front-page space to art—

and more's the pity. But art made headlines throughout the world not long ago, when the great Erickson collection of old masters was sold at auction in New York City. Among the 24 paintings that had been collected by the late advertising magnate Alfred W. Erickson and that had been ordered sold by the executors of his widow's estate, were: one major and two lesser Rembrandts, a Fragonard, a Crivelli and works by Holbein the Younger, Vandyke, Cranach the Elder and Terborch.

The major Rembrandt, *Aristotle Contemplating the Bust of Homer*, and Fragonard's *La Liseuse* were exceptionally choice items over which any collector's or museum curator's mouth would water. It was generally conceded that the paintings would fetch record prices and for weeks before the sale the entire art world buzzed with speculation about the sums likely to be involved and who the highest bidders would be. Top presale estimates were \$1,800,000 for the Rembrandt and \$350,000 for the Fragonard.

Actually, the amounts bid and paid at the auction were far greater than those predicted by even the most educated estimators. *Aristotle Contemplating the Bust of Homer*, the only important Rembrandt not then in a museum, was purchased by New York's Metropolitan Museum of Art, which paid a resounding \$2,300,000 for it.

228

This price was much the highest ever paid for a single painting, twice the previous record \$1,166,400 Andrew Mellon paid the Soviet Government in